Passage One

文章大意

本文主要探讨了学生债务不断增加这一社会问题，该问题在发达国家尤其严重，华尔街抗议者建议要全面免除大学生债务偿还义务，但却遭到了一些人的反对。文章最后提出了有助于解决该问题的方法。

题源时文

Student loans are based on a simple idea: that a graduate's future flow of earnings will more than cover the costs of doing a degree. But with unemployment rates in parts of the rich world at post-war highs, that may no longer hold true for many people.

All over the world student indebtedness is causing problems. In Britain, according to a recent report, rising university fees mean that student debt is likely to *treble*（增为三倍）to £ 70 billion by 2015. But, partly because higher education there is so expensive, the scale of the problem is far greater in America. When the next official estimates of outstanding student debt there are published, it is expected to be close to $1 trillion, higher than credit-card borrowing. Credit quality in other classes of consumer debt has been improving; *delinquency*（拖欠）rates on student loans are rising.

Many of the anti-Wall Street protesters push the idea of blanket debt forgiveness as a solution. But that is the wrong answer. Higher education is not a guarantee of employment, but it improves the odds immensely. Unemployment rates among university graduates stood at 4.4% on average across OECD countries in 2009. People who did not complete secondary school faced unemployment rates of 11.5%. Much of the debt that students are taking on is provided or guaranteed by the government. Imposing *write-offs*（勾销）on all taxpayers to benefit those with the best job prospects is unfair, and ripping up contracts between borrowers and private lenders is usually a bad idea.

That said, student-loan systems in America and elsewhere are often badly designed for an extended period of high unemployment. In contrast to the housing crash, the risk from student debt is not of a sudden explosion in losses but of gradual financial chocking. The pressure needs to be eased.

One option is to change the bankruptcy laws. In America, Britain and elsewhere, these treat student debt as a special case: unlike other forms of debt, it cannot be wiped out. If student debt is not to restrict existing graduates and put off future ones, the rules could be changed so that it is dischargeable in bankruptcy. Yet the reasoning behind the current bankruptcy provisions is logical enough: education is a property that cannot be repossessed and that keeps on benefiting the individual through his or her lifetime. Some worry that graduates would rush to declare bankruptcy, handing losses to taxpayers.

So a second option is preferable. Many countries, America included, have designed student debt primarily as a mortgage like obligation: it is repaid to a fixed schedule. Other places, like Britain and Australia, make student-loan repayments depend on reaching an income threshold so that the prospect of taking on debt is more acceptable to people from poorer backgrounds. That approach makes sense, especially when jobs are scarce. Income-based repayment ought to become the norm.

题源分析

本文选自《经济学人》

核心词汇及短语

bankruptcy *n.* 破产
indebtedness *n.* 债务
preferable *a.* 更好的,更可取的
repossess *v.* 收回
threshold *n.* 门槛;临界值
rip up 撕碎,撕毁
wipe out 消灭,彻底摧毁

Passage Two

文章大意

本文主要叙述了沃尔玛女雇员以歧视女性员工为由发起了一场大规模的集体诉讼。文章开头先解释了集体诉讼的定义,接着阐述了沃尔玛女员工提起诉讼的原因,以及诉讼请求被联邦上诉法院否决的原因。

题源时文

In the American legal system, people generally bring civil claims as individuals. But if a lot of people have similar claims, they may try to bring a class action lawsuit. "A class action is a procedural device under U. S. law that allows a large group of people to bring their individual claims together as a group," said Michael Dorf, a law professor at Cornell University.

But groups need permission to bring a class action, and that can be denied. That happened this week to a million and a half current and former employees of America's largest private employer. The women accuse Wal-Mart of discriminating against female employees in its stores. But the United States Supreme Court voted to block a huge class action against Wal-Mart in federal court.

The women were seeking billions of dollars. They say men were offered more jobs and more chances to move up in the company. They accuse Wal-Mart of violating part of a federal law, the Civil Rights Act of 1964.

The case started about ten years ago. A federal district court in California agreed that the case could go forward as a class action. Wal-Mart again lost in a federal appeals court. But on Monday Wal-Mart won its appeal in the nation's highest court.

Prof. Dorf—who was not involved in the case—says the justices disagreed about whether there was a "common question". A common question, according to the court, is the sort of question which the *plaintiffs* (原告) can prove and thereby go a long way to winning the case.

He says most of the justices found that Wal-Mart was not being accused of one kind of discrimination or one policy, but many different acts. The key to being able to bring a class action here and the issue that divided our Supreme Court was whether all of these different claims—by over a million people—had enough in common to justify a single class action.

Wal-Mart has a policy barring discrimination. But the women accused the company of unfair policies and permitting bad behavior by some store managers.

The court was divided five to four in its ruling. Yet all nine justices agreed that the case could not

go forward. The women needed to meet additional legal requirements because they were seeking payment for harm they say was done. All the justices agreed these requirements had not been met.

Boston University law professor Michael Harper says the decision was widely expected. He says the class action failed because it did not target a single action or policy by Wal-Mart. But the ruling does not bar the women from bringing individual cases. They can also seek class actions at the state level.

题源分析

本文选自《华盛顿邮报》

核心词汇及短语

additional *a.* 额外的,附加的
bar *v.* 禁止,阻拦
block *v.* 阻止,禁止
claim *n.* 要求;索赔
discrimination *n.* 歧视
procedural *a.* 程序上的
class action 集体诉讼;共同诉讼

Passage Three

文章大意

本文介绍了英国约克大学生物学家彼得·梅休的一项最新研究,该研究与以往不同,彼得认为从长期来看,全球变暖可能会导致生物物种的增加。在文章最后,他指出,如果想看到地球上的物种数量随着气温变化而增加,就需要首先抑制地球上的鲁莽行为。

题源时文

University of York biologist Peter Mayhew recently found that global warming might actually increase the number of species on the planet, contrary to a previous report that higher temperatures meant fewer life forms—a report that was his own. In Mayhew's initial 2008 study, low biodiversity among marine *invertebrates* (无脊椎动物) appeared to coincide with warmer temperatures on Earth over the last 520 million years. But Mayhew and his colleagues decided to reexamine their hypothesis, this time using data that were "a fairer sample of the history of life." With this new collection of material, they found a complete reversal of the relationship between species richness and temperature from what their previous paper argued: the number of different groups present in the fossil record was higher, rather than lower, during "greenhouse phases".

Their previous findings rested on an assumption that fossil records can be taken to represent biodiversity changes throughout history. This isn't necessarily the case, because there are certain periods with higher-quality fossil samples, and some that are much more difficult to sample well. Aware of this bias, Mayhew's team used data that standardized the number of fossils examined throughout history and accounted for other variables like sea level changes that might influence biodiversity in their new study to see if their old results would hold up.

Two years later, the results did not. But then why doesn't life increasingly emerge on Earth as our temperatures get warmer? While the switch may prompt some to assert that climate change is not hazardous to living creatures, Mayhew explained that the timescales in his team's study are huge—over 500 million years—and therefore inappropriate for the shorter periods that we might look at as humans

concerned about global warming. Many global warming concerns are focused on the next century, he said—and the lifetime of a species is typically one to 10 million years.

"I do worry that these findings will be used by the climate skeptic community to say 'look, climate warming is fine,'" he said. Not to mention the numerous other things we seem to do to create a storm of threats to biodiversity—think of what *habitat*（栖息地）destruction, over-fishing, and pollution can do for a species-*viability*（生存力）. Those things, Mayhew explained, give the organisms a far greater challenge in coping with climate change than they would have had in the absence of humans.

"If we were to relax all these pressures on biodiversity and allow the world to recover over millions of years in a warmer climate, then my prediction is it would be an improvement in biodiversity," he said. So it looks like we need to curb our reckless treatment of the planet first, if we want to eventually see a surge in the number of species on the planet as temperatures get warmer. We don't have 500 million years to wait.

题源分析

本文选自《时代周刊》

核心词汇及短语

inappropriate *a.* 不适当的,不相称的
reckless *a.* 鲁莽的,不顾后果的
reexamine *v.* 再检查
reversal *n.* 逆转,撤销
standardize *v.* 使标准化;用标准检验
account for 对……解释,说明……的原因
contrary to 与……相反

Passage Four

文章大意

本文介绍一项研究探讨做兼职对青少年发展的影响,并从中得出结论:每周兼职时间超过20个小时的青少年对学习的投入减少,还会产生一些不良行为问题。这应引起人们的重视,并应多方合作限制青少年兼职的时间。

题源时文

Many teens work part-time during the school year, and in the current economic climate, more youths may take jobs to help out with family finances. But caution is advised: Among high school students, working more than 20 hours a week during the school year can lead to academic and behavior problems. That's the finding of a new study by researchers at the University of Washington, University of Virginia, and Temple University. It appears in the January/February issue of the journal, *Child Development*.

In a reanalysis of *longitudinal*(纵向的) data collected in the late 1980s, researchers examined the impact of getting a job or leaving work among middle-class teens in 10th and 11th grades. Drawing from the full sample of about 1,800 individuals, the researchers compared adolescents who got jobs to similar teens who didn't work, and adolescents who left jobs to similar teens who kept working.

Using advances in statistical methods, the researchers matched the teens on a long list of

background and personality characteristics that are known to influence whether or not a young person chooses to work; using this technique allowed more certainty in estimating the effects of working on adolescents' development than in the original analysis of the data.

The researchers found that working for more than 20 hours a week was associated with declines in school engagement and how far adolescents were expected to go in school, and increases in problem behavior such as stealing, carrying a weapon, and using alcohol and illegal drugs. They also found that things didn't get better when teens who were working more than 20 hours a week cut back their hours or stopped working altogether. In contrast, working 20 hours or less a week had negligible academic, psychological, or behavioral effects.

"Working part-time during the school year has been a fixture of American adolescence for more than 30 years," notes Kathryn C. Monahan, a postdoctoral research scientist at the University of Washington, who led the study. "Today, a substantial proportion of American high school students hold part-time jobs during the school year, and a large number of them work more than 20 hours each week."

"Although working during high school is unlikely to turn law-abiding teenagers into criminals or cause students to drop out of school, the extent of the adverse effects we found is not trivial, and even a small decline in school engagement or increase in problem behavior may be of concern to many parents," she adds. The bottom line, suggests Monahan: "Parents, educators, and policymakers should monitor and constrain the number of hours adolescents work while they are enrolled in high school."

题源分析

本文选自《卫报》

核心词汇及短语

constrain *v.* 强迫;束缚
fixture *n.* 固定存在物,固定的事
negligible *a.* 微不足道的,可以忽略的
reanalysis *n.* 重新分析
substantial *a.* 大量的
trivial *a.* 不重要的,琐碎的;琐细的

Passage Five

文章大意

本文主要介绍了几个实验,在这些实验中,实验者发现,人们在受到指责、指认、恐吓的时候会倾向于承认并未做过的事。受试者认为,供认是结束令人不愉快的审讯的一种方式,并认为自己终将会被还以清白。但是在现实世界中,这样做可能导致冤假错案的发生。

题源时文

One of the most recent researches by Saul Kassin and Jennifer Perillo of the John Jay College of Criminal Justice in New York used a group of 71 university students who were told they were taking part in a test of their reaction times. Participants were asked to press keys on a keyboard as they were read aloud by another person, who was secretly in *cahoots* (同伙) with the experimenter. The volunteers were informed that the Alt key was faulty, and that if it was pressed the computer would

crash and all the experimental data would be lost. The experimenter watched the proceedings from across the table.

In fact, the computer was set up to crash regardless, about a minute into the test. When this happened the experimenter asked each participant if he had pressed the illicit key, acted as if he was upset when it was "discovered" that the data had disappeared, and requested that the participant sign a confession. Only one person actually did hit the Alt key by mistake, but a quarter of the innocent participants were so disarmed by the shock of the accusation that they confessed to something they had not done.

A second computer-crash test conducted by Dr. Kassin and Dr. Perillo used this technique. Another person in the room beside the experimenter said he saw the participant hitting the Alt key. In this case the confession rate jumped to 80% of innocent participants. Dr. Horselenberg and his colleagues found something similar.

Dr. Kassin also tested the impact of *bluffing*（恐吓）. Two participants, one of whom was again in cahoots with the investigator, sat in the same room and were asked to complete what appeared to be an academic test. Halfway through, the investigator accused them of helping each other and cited the university's honour code against cheating. The investigator went on to bluff that there was a video camera in the room, though the recording, with its definitive proof one way or the other, would not be accessible until later. Presumably, the innocent participants knew such a tape would *exonerate*（使免除）them. Even so, half still confessed.

All of which is both strange and rather alarming. Dr. Kassin suggests that participants may have the naive—though common—belief that the world is a just place, and that their innocence will emerge in the end, particularly in the case of the alleged video evidence. One participant, for example, told him, "it made it easier (to sign the confession) because I had nothing to hide. The cameras would prove it."

In cases like that, confession is seen as a way to end an unpleasant interrogation. But it is a risky one. In the real world, such faith can be misplaced.

题源分析

本文选自《新科学家》

核心词汇及短语

accusation *n.* 指控
confession *n.* 忏悔;供认
disarm *v.* 解下武器,缴械
illicit *a.* 违法的;不正当的
innocence *n.* 清白,无罪
interrogation *n.* 询问,审讯
presumably *ad.* 大概;可假定;推测起来